

Message 1

The Walk in Truth and Love

Scripture Reading: 2 John 1:1-6

The subject of the Epistle

The subject of this book is the prohibition of participation in heresy. John speaks of heresy in verse 7: “Because many deceivers went out into the world, who do not confess Jesus Christ coming in the flesh. This is the deceiver and the antichrist.” Certain heretics denied that Jesus is the Christ (1 John 2:22), and others denied the Son, not confessing that Jesus is the Son of God (1 John 2:23). Cerinthus, who denied that Jesus is the Christ, was a heretic. The Docetists and the Gnostics also taught heresy concerning the Person of Christ.

The Epistle of 2 John prohibits us from participating in any heretical teaching concerning Christ’s Person. In verse 10 the apostle John says, “If anyone comes to you and does not bring this teaching, do not receive him into your house, and do not say to him, Rejoice!” As in verse 9, the “teaching” here is the teaching concerning the deity of Christ, especially regarding His incarnation by divine conception. In this Epistle John warns us not to receive anyone who denies the truth concerning Christ’s deity and incarnation.

Introduction

Loving in truth for the truth

In verse 1 John says, “The elder to the chosen lady and to her children, whom I love in truth, and not only I, but also all those who have known the truth.” The apostle John, like Peter, was also an elder in the church in Jerusalem before its destruction in A.D. 70 (Gal. 2:9; 1 Pet. 5:1). According to history, after returning from exile, John stayed in Ephesus to care for the churches in Asia. Thus he was probably also an elder in the church at Ephesus, where he wrote this Epistle.

John addresses this Epistle to the “chosen lady and to her children.” The Greek word rendered “lady” is *kuria*, the feminine form of *kurios*, lord, master. There are different interpretations of the word here. The most preferable is that it refers to a Christian sister of some prominence in the church, as “co-chosen” in 1 Peter 5:13 does. *Kuria* may have been her name, since it was a common name at that time. According to some accounts, she lived near Ephesus, and her sister (in v. 13) lived in Ephesus, where the church was under John’s care. There was a church in her locality meeting in her home.

In verse 1 John speaks of loving in truth. According to John’s usage of the word truth, especially in his Gospel, the first instance of “truth” in this verse denotes the revealed divine reality — the Triune God dispensed into man in the Son Jesus Christ — becoming man’s genuineness and sincerity, to live a life that corresponds to the divine light (John 3:19-21) and to worship God, as God seeks, according to what He is (John 4:23-24). This is the virtue of God (Rom. 3:7; 15:8) becoming our virtue, by which we love the believers. This is the genuineness, truthfulness, sincerity, honesty, trustworthiness, and faithfulness of God as a divine virtue and of man as a human virtue (Mark 12:14; 2 Cor. 11:10; Phil. 1:18; 1 John 3:18), and as an issue of the divine reality (3 John 1:1). In such truth, the apostle John, who lived in the divine reality of the Trinity, loved the one to whom he wrote. This is the denotation of the first usage of “truth” in this verse.

Simply speaking, the first usage of truth in verse 1 denotes sincerity, and John is speaking of loving in sincerity. However, the meaning of sincerity here is not simple. Usually, when we speak of sincerity, we understand sincerity to be merely a human virtue. But here sincerity is more than a human virtue. The human virtue in which the apostle John loved the one who received this Epistle was the issue of the divine reality that he enjoyed.

What is the divine reality enjoyed by John? This reality is the Triune God. The writer of this Epistle enjoyed the Triune God in the Son as his divine reality. Out of the enjoyment of this reality, which is the Triune God in Christ, issued sincerity. This sincerity, or faithfulness, actually is a virtue of God. When we enjoy God as our reality, His divine virtue becomes our human virtue, and this human virtue is sincerity, faithfulness.

This understanding of loving in truth is based upon what is revealed in John’s first Epistle. In that Epistle John indicates that we should love one another by God Himself as love. God is love (1 John 4:8, 16). As we enjoy God as love, out of this love issues a love with which we love others. When we love others with the love that issues from our enjoyment of God as love, our love will be in sincerity. This sincerity is not our human virtue; rather, it is the issue of our enjoyment of the divine reality.

As we consider what John means in verse 1 by loving in truth, we are reminded that it is not a superficial matter to know the Bible. In particular, it is not sufficient to know the Epistles of John in a superficial way. Only when we get into the depths of these Epistles can we know the meaning of the writer.

In verse 1 John speaks of “all those who have known the truth.” Here John refers to those who not only have received Christ by believing that He is both God and man, but who also have fully known the truth concerning the Person of Christ.

At the end of verse 1 John again uses the word truth. Here truth denotes the divine reality of the gospel, especially concerning the Person of Christ as revealed in John's Gospel and first Epistle. (See note 6 in 1 John 1, 6.) The divine reality of the gospel here especially includes the fact that Christ is both God and man, having deity and humanity, possessing both the divine nature and the human nature, to express God in human life and to accomplish redemption with divine power in human flesh for fallen human beings, so that He may impart the divine life into them and bring them into an organic union with God. The second and third Epistles of John stress this truth. The second warns the faithful believers against receiving those who do not abide in this truth — in the teaching concerning Christ. The third encourages the believers to receive and help those who work for this truth.

In verse 2 John goes on to say, "Because of the truth which abides in us and shall be with us forever." The apostle John, in his Gospel and first Epistle, inoculated the believers with his mending ministry concerning the revelation of the Person of Christ against the heresies regarding Christ's deity and humanity. Because of such an inoculating truth, he and all those who had known this truth loved those who were faithful to this truth.

In verse 2 John says that the truth abides in us and will be with us forever. In verse 1 he tells us that he and all those who have known the truth love in truth the one to whom this Epistle was written. In verse 2 John uses the word truth with the same meaning as that of the second usage in verse 1, that is, to denote the divine reality of the gospel, especially concerning the Person of Christ. This divine reality, which actually is the Triune God, abides in us now and will be with us for eternity.

Grace, mercy, and peace in truth and love

In verse 3 John says, "Grace, mercy, peace shall be with us from God the Father and from Jesus Christ, the Son of the Father, in truth and love." Truth here refers to the divine reality of the gospel, especially concerning the Person of Christ, who expressed God and accomplished His purpose. Love refers to the expression of the believers in loving one another through receiving and knowing the truth. These two matters are the basic structure of this Epistle. In love and truth, grace, mercy, and peace will be with us.

The apostle greets and blesses the believers with grace, mercy, and peace based upon the existence among them of the two crucial matters of truth and love. When we walk in the truth (v. 4) and love one another (v. 5), we enjoy the divine grace, mercy, and peace.

If truth and love do not exist among the believers, there is no way for them to enjoy grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and from Jesus Christ. Grace, mercy, and peace can be unto us only when the basic factors of truth and love are present. Therefore, this Epistle emphasizes truth and love. All of us need to live a life of truth and love.

The walk in truth and love

In truth

In verses 4 through 6 John speaks concerning the walk in truth and love. Verse 4 says, "I rejoiced greatly that I have found some of your children walking in truth, even as we received commandment from the Father." The truth concerning the Person of Christ is the basic and central element of John's mending ministry. When he found the children of the faithful believer walking in truth, he rejoiced greatly (3 John 1:3-4).

In verse 4 John uses the word "walking." As in 1 John 1:7, where John speaks of walking in the light, the word "walk" means to live, behave, and have our being. The truth concerning the Person of Christ should not only be our belief; it should also be our living.

Once again, truth here denotes the divine reality, especially concerning the Person of Christ. The Father commands us to walk in this reality, that is, in the realization of the divine fact that Jesus Christ is the Son of God (see Matt. 17:5), that we may honor the Son as the Father desires (John 5:23).

The Father commands us to walk in the truth, in the reality. He commands us to walk in the realization of the divine fact that Jesus Christ is the Son of God. If we walk in this reality, we shall honor the Son according to the Father's desire.

In love

In verses 5 and 6 John goes on to say, "And now I ask you, lady, not as writing a new commandment to you, but that which we have had from the beginning, that we should love one another. And this is love, that we walk according to His commandments. This is the commandment, even as you heard from the beginning, that you should walk in it." The phrase "from the beginning" is found a number of times in John's writings. In some instances this phrase is used in the absolute sense (1 John 1:1; 3:8), but here in verses 5 and 6, as elsewhere (John 15:27; 1 John 2:7), it is used in the relative sense.

The commandment referred to in verses 5 and 6 is the commandment given by the Son that we should love one another (John 13:34). The Father commands us to walk in the truth to honor the Son, and the Son commands us to love one another to express Him.

Not Participating in Heresy

Scripture Reading: 2 John 1:7-13

In this message we shall consider verses 7 through 13 of 2 John.

Deceivers and antichrists

Verse 7 says, "Because many deceivers went out into the world, who do not confess Jesus Christ coming in the flesh. This is the deceiver and the antichrist." The deceivers mentioned here were heretics, like the Cerinthians, the false prophets (1 John 4:1).

These deceivers do not confess Jesus Christ coming in the flesh. This means that they do not confess that Jesus is God incarnate. Thus, they deny the deity of Christ. Jesus was conceived of the Spirit (Matt. 1:18). To confess Jesus coming in the flesh is to confess that, as the Son of God, He was divinely conceived to be born in the flesh (Luke 1:31-35). The deceivers, the false prophets, would not make such a confession.

In verse 7 John says that those who do not confess Jesus coming in the flesh are not only deceivers but also antichrists. We have seen that an antichrist differs from a false Christ (Matt. 24:5, 24). A false Christ is one who pretends deceivingly to be the Christ, whereas an antichrist is one who denies Christ's deity, denying that Jesus is the Christ, that is, denying the Father and the Son by denying that Jesus is the Son of God (1 John 2:22), not confessing that He has come in the flesh through the divine conception of the Holy Spirit (1 John 4:2-3). Whoever denies the Person of Christ is an antichrist.

Receiving a full reward

In verse 8 John goes on to say, "Look to yourselves that you do not lose the things which we wrought, but that you may receive a full reward." Here "look to yourselves" means watch yourselves, watch for yourselves, and "lose" means destroy, ruin.

In verse 8 John speaks of not losing the things which we wrought. The things which the apostles wrought are the things of the truth concerning Christ, which the apostles ministered and imparted to the believers. To be influenced by the heresies regarding the Person of Christ is to lose, destroy, and ruin the precious things concerning the Person of Christ which the apostles had wrought into the believers. Here the apostle warns the believers to watch for themselves lest they be influenced by the heresies and lose the things of the truth.

In verse 8 John also indicates that the believers "may receive a full reward." According to the context, especially verse 9, the full reward must be the Father and the Son as the full enjoyment to the faithful believers, who abide in the truth concerning the Person of Christ and do not deviate from it by the influence of the heresies regarding Christ. This interpretation is justified by the fact that there is no indication this reward will be given in the future, as the rewards mentioned in Matt. 5:12; 16:27; 1 Cor. 3:8, 13-14; Heb. 10:35-36; Rev. 11:18 and Rev. 22:12. If we are not led astray by the heresies, but abide faithfully in the truth concerning the wonderful and all-inclusive Christ who is both God and man, both our Creator and Redeemer, we shall enjoy in Him the Triune God to the fullest extent as our full reward, even today on earth.

If we lose the precious things wrought into us by the apostles, this means that we do not abide in the truth. Then we shall miss the enjoyment of the Father and the Son. But if we stay in the truth, we shall receive a full reward, a reward that is actually the enjoyment of the Father and the Son. Praise the Lord that such a reward is in view waiting to be enjoyed by us! To enjoy this reward, we need to remain, abide, in the divine truth concerning Jesus Christ, the Son of God. Those, like today's modernists, who do not abide in this truth certainly do not have this enjoyment. For them, there is no reward of the Father and the Son as their enjoyment. If you contact them, you will find them spiritually starved and dry.

Going beyond and not abiding in the teaching of Christ

In verse 9 John continues, "Everyone who goes beyond and does not abide in the teaching of Christ, does not have God; he who abides in the teaching, this one has both the Father and the Son." Literally, the Greek word translated "goes beyond" means to lead forward (in a negative sense), that is, to go further than what is right, to advance beyond the limit of orthodox teaching concerning Christ. This is contrasted with abiding in the teaching of Christ. The Cerinthian Gnostics, who boasted of their supposedly advanced thinking concerning the teaching of Christ, had such a practice. They went beyond the teaching of the divine conception of Christ, thus denying the deity of Christ. Consequently they could not have God in salvation and in life.

The modernists today go beyond and do not abide in the teaching of Christ. They also claim to be advanced in their thinking. According to them, it is out of date to say that Christ is God, that He was born of a virgin through divine conception, that He died on the cross for our sins, and that He was resurrected both physically and spiritually. Denying this truth concerning Christ, the modernists claim to be advanced in their philosophical thought. In principle, they follow the way of the Cerinthian Gnostics.

In verse 9 John speaks of not abiding in the teaching of Christ. This is not the teaching by Christ, but the teaching concerning Christ, that is, the truth concerning the deity of Christ, especially regarding His incarnation by divine conception.

Having the Father and the Son

According to verse 9, the one who goes beyond and does not abide in the teaching of Christ, does not have God. But he who abides in the teaching of Christ has both the Father and the Son. To "have God" is to "have both the Father and the Son." It is through the process of incarnation that God has been dispensed to us in the Son with the Father (1 John 2:23) for our enjoyment and reality (John 1:1, 14). In the incarnated God we have the Son in His redemption and the Father in His life. We are thus redeemed and regenerated to be one with God organically so that we may partake of and enjoy Him in salvation and in life. Hence, to deny the incarnation is to reject this divine enjoyment; but to abide in the truth of incarnation is to have God, as the Father and the Son, for our portion in the eternal salvation and in the divine life.

This point in verse 9 concerning having both the Father and the Son has helped me to interpret the full reward spoken of in verse 8. The full reward is to have both the Father and the Son for our enjoyment. Today's modernists, like the ancient Gnostics, do not have the Father and the Son, for they do not abide in the teaching of Christ.

Not sharing in heretical works

In verse 10 John goes on to say, "If anyone comes to you and does not bring this teaching, do not receive him into your house, and do not say to him, Rejoice!" Concerning the teaching of Christ, we should not only teach this as a theory, but also bring it as a reality. Wherever we go, we should bring this reality, the reality of what the all-inclusive Christ is. Some of the young people may have an opportunity to present to their parents this reality, which is a wonderful treasure.

In verse 10 the pronoun "him" refers to a heretic, an antichrist (v. 7; 1 John 2:22), a false prophet (1 John 4:1), who denies the divine conception and deity of Christ, as today's modernists do. Such a one we must reject, not receiving him into our house or greeting him. Thus, we shall not have any contact with him or share in his heresy, heresy that is blasphemous to God and contagious like leprosy.

We should not receive anyone who does not bring with him the teaching of Christ. Do not think that because we are told to love others, we should receive a heretic. Concerning this, love does not avail. John says clearly that we should not receive an antichrist, a false prophet, into our house, and we should not even say to him, "Rejoice!"

The Greek word for rejoice is *chairein*, be happy, rejoice, hail; it is used for greeting or farewell. Instead of telling false prophets to rejoice, we should tell them to weep because they do not have the enjoyment of the Triune God. The point here is that we should have nothing to do with such persons and with their contagious heresy.

In verse 11 John says, "For he who says to him, Rejoice, shares in his evil works." Just as bringing to others the divine truth of the wonderful Christ is an excellent deed (Rom. 10:15), so spreading the satanic heresy, which defiles the glorious deity of Christ, is an evil work. It is a blasphemy and abomination to God! It is also a damage and curse to men. No believer in Christ and child of God should have any share in this evil. Even to greet such an evil one is prohibited. A severe and clear separation from this evil should be maintained.

The New Testament is very strong in the matter of not receiving one who denies the Person of Christ. Even though the second Epistle of John is an Epistle about loving one another, here John prohibits us from sharing, participating, in heresy. We should not have any contact with heretics, false prophets. We should not receive them, and we should not greet them. They are lepers, and this leprosy is contagious. Therefore, we should have nothing to do with them.

John's conclusion in this Epistle

Hope of closer fellowship for more joy

In verses 12 and 13 we have the conclusion of this Epistle. In verse 12 John expresses the hope of closer fellowship for more joy: "Having many things to write to you, I do not want to do so with paper and ink, but I am hoping to be with you and to speak mouth to mouth, that our joy may be made full." Here the apostle expresses his desire for a deeper and richer fellowship with the church member for fullness of joy in the enjoyment of the divine life (1 John 1:2-4).

On the one hand, John's writing is divine; on the other hand, he is very human in his behavior. We see this humanness in verse 12, where John expresses his hope for fellowship that He describes as mouth to mouth.

Greeting in the endearing care

In verse 13 John says, "The children of your chosen sister greet you." This indicates what an intimate fellowship with the church members and what an endearing care for them the aged elder had.

We have pointed out that the sister to whom this Epistle was written may have lived near Ephesus and that her sister lived in Ephesus, where there was a church under John's care. In this Epistle John greets the one who received this Epistle on behalf of the children of her chosen sister. That she was not included in the greeting may indicate that she was deceased. However, her children were still in the church at Ephesus under John's care. In this verse we can see the endearing care of the apostle John for the saints.

The divine reality

The three Epistles of John are arranged in a good sequence. No doubt, the writing of the second Epistle was based upon the first. In the first Epistle of John we see what the divine truth is.

In 1975 I gave a series of messages on the seven mysteries in 1 John: the mystery of the divine life, the mystery of the divine fellowship, the mystery of the abiding, the mystery of the anointing, the mystery of the divine birth, the mystery of the divine seed, and the mystery of the water, the blood, and the Spirit. Recently, I have been deeply impressed with the divine reality in John's first Epistle. The central factor in 1 John is the divine reality. This reality is actually the Triune God. The divine reality is the Triune God not merely in theology or doctrine; this reality is the Triune God in our experience, that is, the Triune God dispensed into us for our enjoyment. This is the divine reality in 1 John.

The enjoyment of the Triune God

If you review the messages given in the Life-study of 1 John, you will see that in those messages the divine reality is ministered to you. Of course, in those messages there is ministered to us the eternal life, the fellowship of the divine life, the abiding in the Lord, the anointing, the divine birth, the divine seed, and the water, the blood, and the Spirit. When all these divine factors are put together, what we have is the enjoyment of the Triune God. Hence, the Triune God is the reality, the truth, we are enjoying. What are we doing day by day in the Christian life? We are enjoying the Triune God. If you were to ask me what I have been doing for more than fifty years, I would answer that I have been enjoying the Father, the Son, and the Spirit. As a result of my enjoyment of the Triune God, I have been burdened to share this enjoyment with others. However, because of the influence of traditional teaching, certain ones are not open to hear about the enjoyment of the Triune God.

People everywhere need to hear of the divine reality in the Epistle of 1 John. Do you not believe that this is what others, including religious leaders and Bible teachers, need today? Some recite the Apostles' Creed in their services every week, yet they are not saved and do not have any experience of the Triune God. We thank the Lord for opening to us the Epistle of 1 John, a book that contains course after course for our spiritual nourishment. Oh, what riches of our Triune God are revealed in this Epistle for our experience and enjoyment!

The true God becoming our experience

According to 1 John 5:20, we not only experience and enjoy the Triune God, but we are in Him: "And we know that the Son of God has come, and has given us an understanding that we might know Him who is true; and we are in Him who is true, in His Son Jesus Christ. This is the true God and eternal life." We have pointed out that a better translation of "Him who is true" would be "the true One." Actually, the Greek simply says "the true." Only our Triune God is true; everything and everyone else is false. John tells us that we are in the True, in His Son Jesus Christ. No longer are we outside the True, and no longer are we outside His Son Jesus Christ.

In the second part of 1 John 5:20, John goes on to say, "This is the true God and eternal life." The true God becomes our experience as eternal life. This is the basic factor of John's first Epistle.

In 1 John we have the enjoyment of the Triune God as eternal life. Because we are in the true God, He contains us. When we are in the true God, He becomes eternal life to us.

In 1 John 5:20 we have the true One, Jesus Christ, the true God, and eternal life. In John's concept all these are one. However, in doctrine they are four: the true One, His Son Jesus Christ, the true God, and eternal life. But in our experience they are one. When we are in the true One, we are in His Son Jesus Christ. Then the true One becomes our God, and His Son Jesus Christ becomes eternal life to us. This eternal life is actually the true God. Furthermore, because the true God is real to us, in our experience He becomes our eternal life. This is the true God and eternal life.

Sincerity as the issue of the enjoyment of the divine reality

John's second Epistle is based upon the truth revealed in his first Epistle. Second John 1 says, "The elder to the chosen lady and to her children, whom I love in truth, and not only I, but also all those who have known the truth." In the foregoing message we pointed out that the first instance of "truth" in this verse denotes the revealed divine reality — the Triune God dispensed into man in the Son Jesus Christ — becoming man's genuineness and sincerity. This sincerity is the issue of the enjoyment of the divine reality. Hence, when John says that he loves in truth, he is saying that he loves in a sincerity that is the issue of the divine reality. We have also seen that the second usage of truth in this verse denotes the divine reality of the gospel, especially concerning the Person of Christ. This is "the truth which abides in us and shall be with us forever" (v. 2). These verses are simple, but their implication is profound. The entire first Epistle of John is needed for the explanation of the first two verses of his second Epistle.

Walking in truth and love

After speaking concerning truth in verses 1 through 3, John goes on to tell us in verses 4 through 6 that we need to walk in truth and love. Truth is the reality of the Trinity, and love is the expression of this reality. When we walk in truth, we walk in the divine reality we enjoy daily. Love is the expression of this reality. As we walk in the divine reality, spontaneously we love others. This love is the expression of the divine reality we enjoy day by day. Because of this reality and love, grace, mercy, and peace are with us (v. 3). Praise the Lord that we may walk in the divine reality and in the divine expression!